

this mobile device as a notebook or tablet. Weighing only 1 to 2 kilograms, ultrabooks fully match the performance of a conventional notebook.

Ultrabooks have been launched by companies like Wipro, Samsung, Acer, Lenovo, Toshiba, Dell and Hewlett Packard.

7 Home networking—an unbroken trend

Consumer electronics devices that are part of a home network and communicate with household appliances, heating and lighting systems are yet another innovation that in the years to come will represent an increasingly important trend.

Incorporating individual components into networks opens up huge possibilities. Photos, music and videos are no longer stored on shelves and in albums. Nowadays these are archived digitally on PCs, notebooks and network hard drives and, via the home network, can be retrieved by virtually any digital device—be it a smartphone, networked TV set or a tablet. Standards such as UPnP and DLNA make accessing media in a home network easy. The network components recognise each other automatically and are thus able to exchange digital content.

The trend towards networked media access has also profoundly changed the world of hi-fi. Nowadays it is possible to set up a home network with fixed or wireless connections

that incorporates innumerable music components and surround systems and retrieves media from a single location. In such cases, smartphones function as easy-to-operate remote controls which, using special apps, can navigate music archives.

Radios also have a firm place in the networked household. Audio components in a home network can usually access the Internet where they can find a huge trove of local and international digital radio stations. Thus the Web has become one of the most important disseminators of digital radio content.

Users can also access their home network while on the move—for example, in order to retrieve stored information or to program a video recording.

Communication between consumer electronics components and household appliances opens up a wealth of possibilities for future applications. Washing machines can be monitored via a smartphone or tablet while their owners are on the move. The lighting or blinds in the house can be activated even when on holiday. When shopping, users can be alerted to low food stocks in the fridge.

Incorporating more and more components into a digitally networked world creates an even greater potential for new applications. As a result, hardly anything can stand in the way of the imagination of developers, engineers and scientists. ●

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